PAIRED TEXTS stories that share a topic or theme



This Apple Could Have Been Saved

The shocking story of how Americans waste millions of tons of food every year. And yes, **YOU** can help stop this.

BY KRISTIN LEWIS, WITH REPORTING BY ADEE BRAUN

ROC CANALS PHOTOGRAPHY/GETTY IMAGES

AS YOU READ What are the causes and effects of food waste?

Here's a field trip for you: After lunch, walk over to the Dumpster at your school. Pry open the top and take a look inside. (Don't fall in!) What do you see? Trash, right? Banana peels, ketchup-smeared napkins, plates crusted with pudding.

But wait. *Really* get your face in there. (You might want to hold your nose.)

What else do you see?

A tuna sandwich with just one bite taken out of it. A half-eaten burrito. Heaps of crispy lettuce, glistening with ranch dressing. Bright baby carrots sprinkled around like orange confetti. And not one but *six* shiny red apples.

This is an example of what is typically left behind after just one lunch period, at one school, on one day. Now imagine that one Dumpster multiplied hundreds of thousands of times across the country. Dumpsters sit behind not just schools but also restaurants, apartment buildings, grocery stores—the list goes on. And day after day, all those Dumpsters get filled up with perfectly **edible** food.

According to the U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA), $160 billion worth of food gets thrown away each year. If we were to fill up shopping carts with all the food we throw away every week and line them up, the carts would stretch around the Earth—almost twice. Yet at the same time, one in six people in the U.S. doesn't have enough to eat.

How is this possible? Welcome to the problem of food waste.

JONATHON KAMBOURIS/GALLERYSTOCK

A Leftovers Nation

Not so long ago, throwing away your half-eaten sandwich would have been as unthinkable as throwing away your phone. Until the late 1800s, most Americans ate food that they grew or raised themselves. Milk came from cows milked before dawn. Meat came from animals raised in the barn. Fruits and vegetables grew in fields that the whole family tended. One bad storm could wipe out a season's harvest. Depending on where you lived, the nearest store could be a day's buggy ride away—or farther. Plus, few had money to spare for buying food. Starvation was a huge threat.

And so, every crust of bread and drop of milk was precious. Meat and potatoes from yesterday's dinner became tomorrow's breakfast. Kitchen scraps were boiled into stews, baked into pies, or fed to horses and chickens. Fruits were jammed and meats were salted or smoked, preserving them for months.

What couldn't be consumed was put to use too. Cow skin was fashioned into leather shoes. Pig bladders were made into balls to kick around after school. Corn husks were stitched into mattresses, and animal fat was turned into candles and soap.

By 1900, times had begun to change. Families were leaving their farms and moving to towns and cities. Food was becoming cheaper and easier to get. Still, many Americans were careful to **conserve**. They knew that food could not be taken for granted.

In the early years of the 20th century, people were reminded of this again and again. Two world wars put a big strain on America's food supply.

THE NUMBERS

Every time food ends up in the trash, we're wasting more than just food. We're wasting the chance to help someone.

14 PERCENT

of American households are "food insecure," meaning they don't know where their next meal will come from.

25 MILLION

people could be fed each year if we threw away just 15 percent less of what we currently toss.

SOURCES: USDA, NRDC



And in the years between the wars there was the Great Depression.

In this period of widespread unemployment and poverty, hunger threatened millions. Families had to get creative or go hungry. "Depression soup"—one-third cup of ketchup and two-thirds cup of boiling water—became popular. So did bacon grease sandwiches. Squirrels, possums, even road kill became important sources of protein.

A Nation of Wasters

So how did we go from being a nation of savers to being a nation of wasters?

By the 1950s and 1960s, the U.S. was growing again—fast. New roads and bridges connected America from coast to coast. Refrigerated trucks could now carry fresh produce across the country on a scale never before seen. Fresh strawberries from California could be enjoyed 3,000 miles away in New York.

Most exciting of all?

Supermarkets.

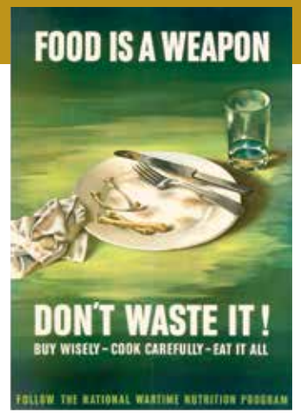
Americans were dazzled by these stores—and it's no wonder. After decades of hardship and hunger, supermarkets must have seemed like heaven. They were clean, bright, modern, and, best of all, overflowing with food. It seemed like every day, a new supermarket was opening somewhere—always with great fanfare.

At the same time, food was getting a lot cheaper. By the 1970s, Americans were spending half as much as their parents had on food. People started packing their refrigerators in a way they never had before—filling them with more than they could hope to eat.

But as America's refrigerators swelled, so did something else: America's trash.

SAVE FOOD, WIN THE WAR

During World War II, families were expected to conserve food. The government appealed to people's patriotism with posters like this one.



TOUGH TIMES

During the Great Depression in the 1930s, millions of Americans couldn't get jobs. Masses of people waited in lines that stretched for city blocks, for a small meal.



BETTMANN/GETTY IMAGES (BREADLINE); JONATHAN KIRN/CORBIS VIA GETTY IMAGES (HORSE PLOW)

Perfect Peppers

Here are some questions for you: Do you know how to pluck the feathers from a chicken? Can you **pickle** an artichoke? Do you know whether cucumbers grow on trees or on vines? If your answer is "no" to any (or all) of those questions, don't worry. You aren't alone. Few Americans know much about what happens to food before it arrives at the dinner table.

Why would we? In the U.S. today, we have the incredible privilege of not having to worry about food the way our ancestors did, which gives us time to focus on other things: school, sports, family, friends.

For most of us, our relationship with the food we eat begins at the grocery store. There, we expect to find the shelves fully stocked with fresh, beautiful food every time we visit. In fact, we want our fruits and veggies to be as flawless-looking as celebrities on the red carpet. (Who wants to buy a slightly bruised tomato, even if it does taste exactly the same as an unbruised one?)

What most of us don't think about is that to meet our expectations of shelves bursting with fresh, photo-ready food, stores must order more than they can sell. That means baskets of perfect peppers and boxes of perfectly good oranges get chucked to make room for the next shipment. Misshapen—but still tasty—produce often never gets to the shelf in the first place, because customers won't buy it. Instead, it goes straight to the garbage bin. And so grocery stores end up throwing away 43 billion pounds of food a year. Meanwhile, on farms, foods that don't look great are left to rot; there's no point in taking the time, energy, and expense to harvest a crop that no store will try to sell.

TY WRIGHT/BLOOMBERG VIA GETTY IMAGES (COMPACTOR)



A compactor packs down trash at the Defiance County Landfill in Ohio.

WASTED FOOD, WASTED WATER

Eighty percent of the fresh water that we consume is used to grow food. Yet we end up throwing nearly half of that food away. "When you throw out a burger, that's the equivalent of taking a 90-minute shower," says Dana Gunders from the Natural Resources Defense Council. "Throwing out an apple is like taking a seven-minute shower."



GROW IT, EAT IT

At the end of the 19th century, you probably would have lived on a farm like this. (Most Americans did.) You and your siblings would spend your days in the fields, helping your parents grow food that you would carefully preserve, so it would last all year.

Let's Face It

Even a lot of the food that we do buy ends up in the trash. At school, you might toss your half-eaten bag of pretzels because that's easier than carrying it around in your backpack all afternoon. Your parents, exhausted after a long day at work, might opt to order a pizza instead of cooking

the chicken in the refrigerator. We often toss our leftovers because it's easier than putting them away—and when we do save our leftovers, they are often abandoned to spoil at the back of the fridge, because, let's face it, most food doesn't taste *quite* as good the second time around.

Each time we throw food away, we are wasting more than just that food. We are also wasting the hard work, time, water, and fuel it took to get that food into our hands. (According to food waste expert Jonathan Bloom, a typical supermarket item travels 1,500 miles to get to us.)

And then there's the issue of what happens to all that food after we chuck it.

A Stinky Mess

Remember that Dumpster outside your cafeteria?

Ever wonder what happens to all that stuff inside?

First, it is probably collected by a garbage truck and taken to a processing center. From there, it is likely shipped to a landfill.

And in the landfill, it contributes to a **festering**, **putrid** mess.

According to the Natural Resources Defense Council, food is the number one type of garbage in America's landfills. As it **decomposes**, this food emits methane, a gas that pollutes the air and soil. Some landfills have ways to prevent methane from escaping, but they may not be able to catch all of it. It's no surprise, then, that the food filling up our landfills is one of the biggest environmental problems facing the U.S. right now.

What Now?

Fortunately, the problem of food waste is starting to get attention. In the past few years, journalists, government agencies, environmental activists, students like you—even President Barack Obama's administration—have been sounding the alarm. And that's great news. According to Andrew Shakman, CEO of an anti-food-waste company called LeanPath, ending food waste begins with awareness.

"People need to realize that a convenience-oriented society leads to waste," says Shakman. "We can change the culture by changing awareness."

In other words, the more we understand about how our behavior affects our world, the more likely we will be to change.

In fact, small changes are already happening. Some restaurants have started offering smaller portions, so less food gets scraped into the trash. Some schools have begun **composting** or donating leftovers from their cafeterias to local food banks. New York City now provides compost bins to some neighborhoods and plans to add more. Some Walmarts now sell so-called ugly produce at big discounts. And several Whole Foods stores in California are doing the same.

Whether these measures go far enough, only time will tell.

In the meantime, there is one easy way you can help. Next time you think about dropping that spaghetti into the trash (or that half-eaten apple or that extra portion of roasted potatoes), save it for later instead.

It will taste great . . . and the Earth will thank you. ●

What We Waste

Food waste isn't a problem just in America. It's a problem worldwide. About 1.3 billion tons of food—about a third of all food produced around the world—gets wasted every year.





45% OF ALL PRODUCE



35% OF ALL SEAFOOD



30% OF ALL CEREALS



20% OF ALL DAIRY



20% OF ALL MEAT

SOURCE: FOOD AND AGRICULTURE ORGANIZATION OF THE UNITED STATES

SHUTTERSTOCK (ALL IMAGES)

Informational Text

How to Reduce Your Food Waste

It's Easier Than You Think!



1 Use smaller plates.
The larger the plate, the more likely you'll be to fill it with food you won't end up eating. So start small. You can always go back for seconds!



2 Start a food donation program in your school.
Collect extra food from your cafeteria and your classmates' lunches to donate to organizations that help those in need.



3 Eat what you have before buying more.
Talk to your family about using up what's already in the kitchen before shopping for more. Is some of it looking a little tired? Wilted veggies can be tossed into soups, baked into casseroles, or sautéed and served over rice. Stale bread can be turned into toast or croutons. Overripe fruits can be frozen, then served over ice cream or yogurt, mixed into smoothies, baked into muffins, or cooked into pancakes.



4 Eat "ugly" produce.
Bruised bananas and plums, misshapen potatoes and carrots—they all taste fine.



5 Compost.
Composting is a way to turn organic materials—stuff like banana peels, eggshells, and apple cores—into rich soil that is great for gardening. Compost at home with a special bin, or take food scraps to a city composting site.



6 Save and share.
Didn't finish your lunch? Offer it to a friend, save it for snacking, or take it back home. Turn restaurant leftovers into great next-day lunches.



7 Eat expired food. (Seriously.)
Foods past their "best by" or "use by" dates are often safe to eat. Those dates are just estimates of when the food will be freshest—they have nothing to do with safety. (Of course, if something smells bad or tastes funky, don't eat it!)

WESTEND61/SUPERSTOCK (SANDWICH); PETER DAZELEY/GETTY IMAGES (COMPOST); CREATIV STUDIO HEINEMANN/IMAGEBROKER/SUPERSTOCK (CAN); SHUTTERSTOCK (ALL OTHER IMAGES)

WRITING CONTEST

In two well-organized paragraphs, explain two ideas for reducing food waste and why each idea would work. Use text evidence. Send your response to **FOOD WASTE CONTEST**. Five winners will each get *Return to Sender* by Julia Alvarez. See page 2 for details.



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